Heart Disease Risk Prediction: End-to-End MLOps Pipeline

Machine Learning Operations (AIMLCZG523) · Assignment 01
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Code repository: https://github.com/jpailabs/heart-disease-mlops (private; grant access to the evaluator) **API access:** see §8 (local Kubernetes via Ingress at `http://localhost:8088`)

1. Executive summary

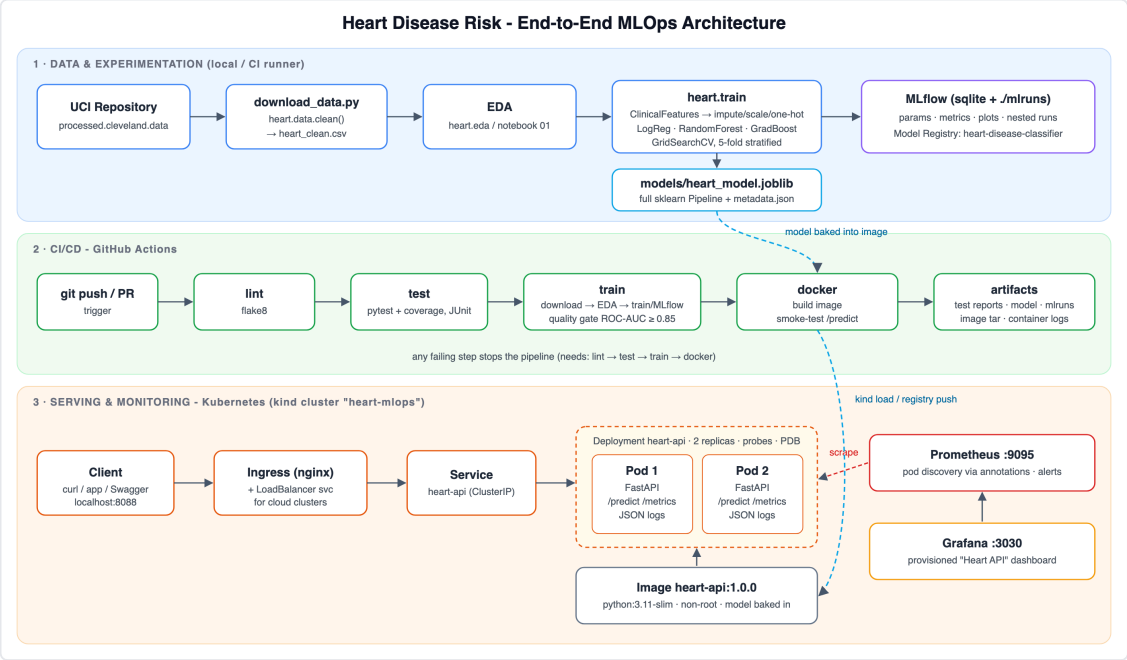
This project builds a classifier that predicts whether a patient has heart disease from 13 routine clinical measurements, using the UCI Heart Disease (Cleveland) dataset. The model is served as a monitored REST API on Kubernetes. Every stage is automated and reproducible:

Stage	Implementation
Data acquisition	`scripts/download_data.py` downloads the file from UCI; `heart.data.clean()` cleans it
EDA	`heart.eda` and notebook `01_eda.ipynb` (7 figures)
Features	custom `ClinicalFeatures` transformer, plus imputation, scaling and one-hot encoding in one sklearn `Pipeline`
Models	Logistic Regression, Random Forest and Gradient Boosting, each tuned with `GridSearchCV` (5-fold stratified CV)
Tracking	MLflow (SQLite backend): 80 runs (parent + nested grid points), plots, a model registry
Packaging	`heart_model.joblib` (full pipeline), an MLflow model with signature, pinned and locked requirements
CI/CD	GitHub Actions: lint → test → train with quality gate → Docker build and smoke test, with artifacts at each stage

Stage	Implementation
Serving	FastAPI with input validation; `/predict` returns a prediction plus a confidence score
Deployment	kind Kubernetes cluster: 2 replicas, probes, PDB, Ingress (nginx) and a LoadBalancer service
Monitoring	structured JSON request logs; Prometheus (per-pod scraping, alert rules); a provisioned Grafana dashboard

Result. Tuned Logistic Regression was selected. Its mean 5-fold CV ROC-AUC is **0.908**. On the hold-out test set it scores ROC-AUC **0.959**, accuracy **0.869** and recall **0.929**.

2. Architecture



End-to-end architecture

There are three layers:

1. **Data & experimentation.** These steps run locally or on the CI runner. They produce the cleaned dataset, the EDA figures, MLflow runs and the model artefact.
2. **CI/CD.** The GitHub Actions pipeline repeats the experimentation steps from scratch on every push. It gates on model quality, then builds and tests the container.
3. **Serving & monitoring.** The image runs on Kubernetes behind an Ingress. Prometheus scrapes every pod and Grafana shows service and model metrics.

Design decisions

- **One pipeline object.** Feature engineering, imputation, scaling and encoding all live inside a single sklearn `Pipeline`. Training, notebooks and the API therefore run identical preprocessing code, which rules out training/serving skew.
- **Model baked into the image.** The image is immutable and versioned (`heart-api:1.0.0`). A rollout or rollback is just an image tag change. The MLflow registry keeps the full lineage (run id → image metadata via `/model-info`).
- **Per-pod scraping.** Prometheus uses Kubernetes pod discovery driven by `prometheus.io/*` annotations, not the Service. Scraping through the Service would land on a random replica each time and give inconsistent counters.

3. Setup and installation

```
python3.11 -m venv .venv && source .venv/bin/activate
pip install -r requirements.txt && pip install -e .
python scripts/download_data.py      # data
python -m heart.eda                  # EDA figures
python -m heart.train --register     # tuning + MLflow + model artefact
pytest && flake8 src api tests scripts
./scripts/deploy_kind.sh             # Docker build + kind + Ingress + monitoring
./scripts/smoke_test.sh http://localhost:8088 100
```

There are three requirement files:

- `requirements.txt` pins direct dependencies.
- `requirements-lock.txt` is a full `pip freeze` (168 packages) for exact rebuilds.
- `requirements-serve.txt` contains the 8 runtime packages used in the slim serving image.

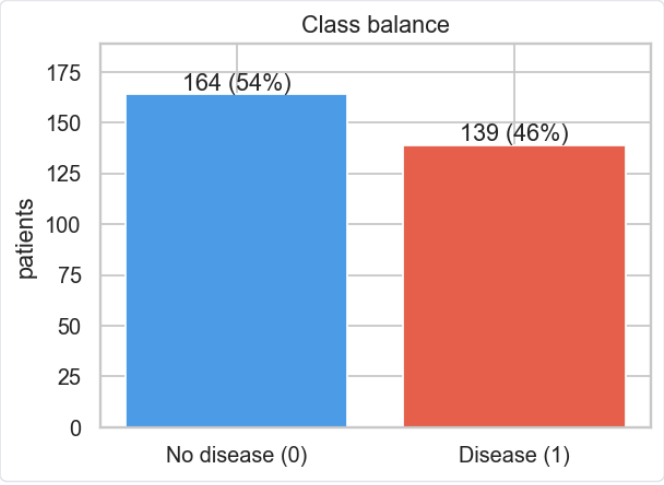
The whole sequence was run from a fresh virtual environment. Running the pipeline again (`scripts/ci_local.sh`) gave identical metrics, because every random seed is fixed to 42.

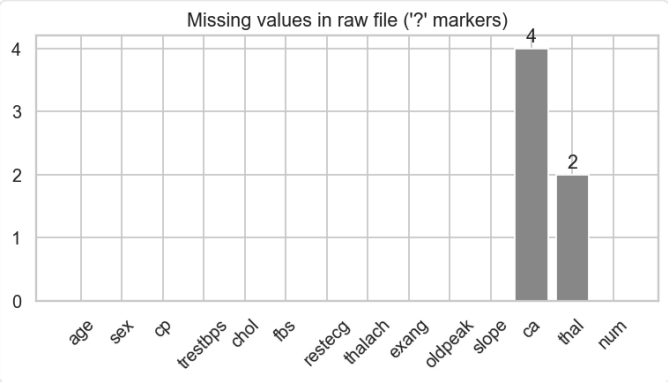
4. Data acquisition and EDA

Source. `processed.cleveland.data` from the UCI Machine Learning Repository: 303 patients, 13 features and the `num` diagnosis (0-4). The file has no header row, and missing values are written as `?`.

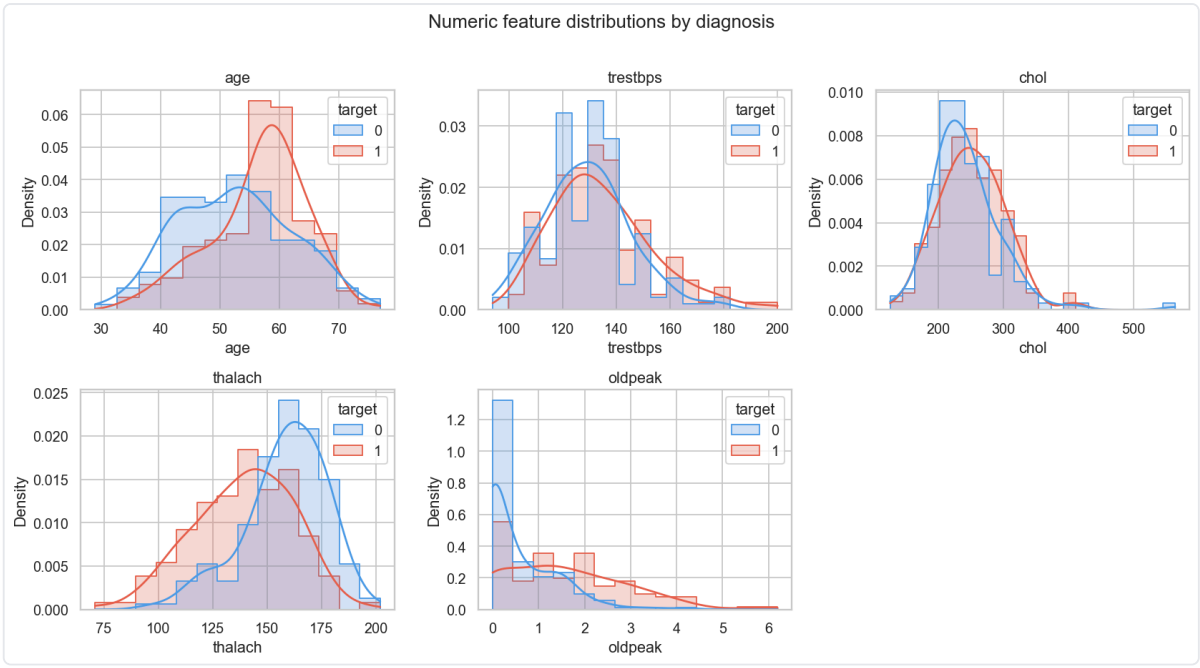
Cleaning (`heart.data.clean`)

- Every column is coerced to numeric. `?` becomes NaN.
- Exact duplicate rows are dropped (there are none in Cleveland).
- Codes outside the documented ranges (e.g. `cp ∉ {1..4}`, `thal ∉ {3,6,7}`) and impossible values (`chol ≤ 0`, `trestbps ≤ 0`) are set to NaN. This protects the pipeline against corrupted inputs; the unit tests cover it.
- The target is binarised: `target = 1 if num > 0`. Classes 1-4 all mean that disease is present.
- Missing values (`ca`: 4, `thal`: 2) are **not** imputed at this stage. They are imputed inside the model pipeline (median for numeric, mode for categorical), fitted on the training fold only, so the CV estimates contain no leakage.

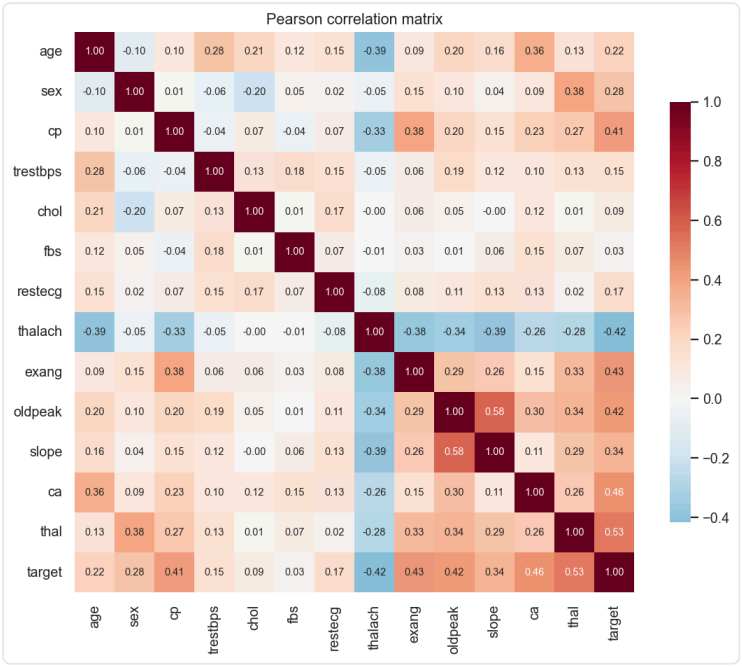




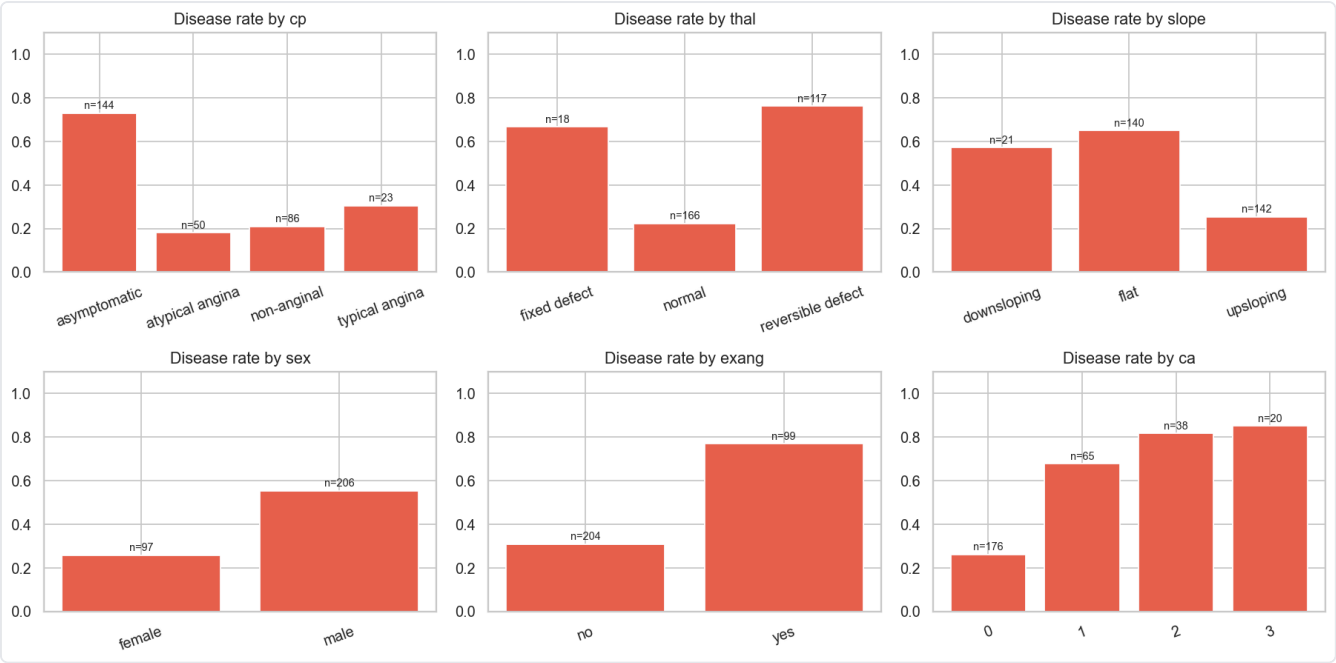
The classes are mildly imbalanced: 54 % no disease and 46 % disease. Stratified splits are used everywhere, and `class_weight` is part of the tuning grid.



Distributions of numeric features by diagnosis



Correlation heatmap



Disease rate per categorical level

Key findings

- The strongest correlations with the target are `thal` (0.53), `ca` (0.46), `exang` (0.43), `oldpeak` (0.43), `thalach` (–0.42) and `cp` (0.41).
- Patients with disease reach a **lower peak heart rate** and show **more exercise-induced ST depression**. `chol` and `trestbps` separate the classes only weakly.
- Asymptomatic chest pain (`cp = 4`) and a reversible thallium defect (`thal = 7`) have disease rates above 70 %. These are nominal codes, so they are **one-hot encoded**, not treated as ordinal numbers.
- The box plots show a few high cholesterol values (up to 564 mg/dl). They are clinically plausible, so they are kept, and standard scaling limits their influence on the linear model.

5. Feature engineering and model development

Feature pipeline (`heart.features`)

Group	Columns	Transform
Engineered	`hr_reserve_pct = thalach / (220 − age)`, `chol_age_ratio = chol / age`	computed by the `ClinicalFeatures` transformer
Numeric	age, trestbps, chol, thalach, oldpeak, ca, plus the 2 engineered columns	median impute → `StandardScaler`
Binary	sex, fbs, exang	mode impute
Nominal	cp, restecg, slope, thal	mode impute → `OneHotEncoder(handle_unknown="ignore")`

This gives 24 model features. `hr_reserve_pct` encodes *chronotropic incompetence*: failing to reach about 85 % of the age-predicted maximum heart rate is a recognised cardiac risk marker. Raw `thalach` mixes that effect with age.

Protocol

- 80/20 stratified train/test split (242 / 61 patients). The test set is used **only** for the final report.

- Each model family is tuned with `GridSearchCV` (scoring = ROC-AUC, `StratifiedKFold(5, shuffle, seed 42)`).
- The tuned estimator is then re-scored with `cross_validate` on accuracy, precision, recall, F1 and ROC-AUC.
- Selection rule: highest mean CV ROC-AUC, with ties broken by CV recall. A missed disease case (false negative) costs more than a false alarm.

Search spaces

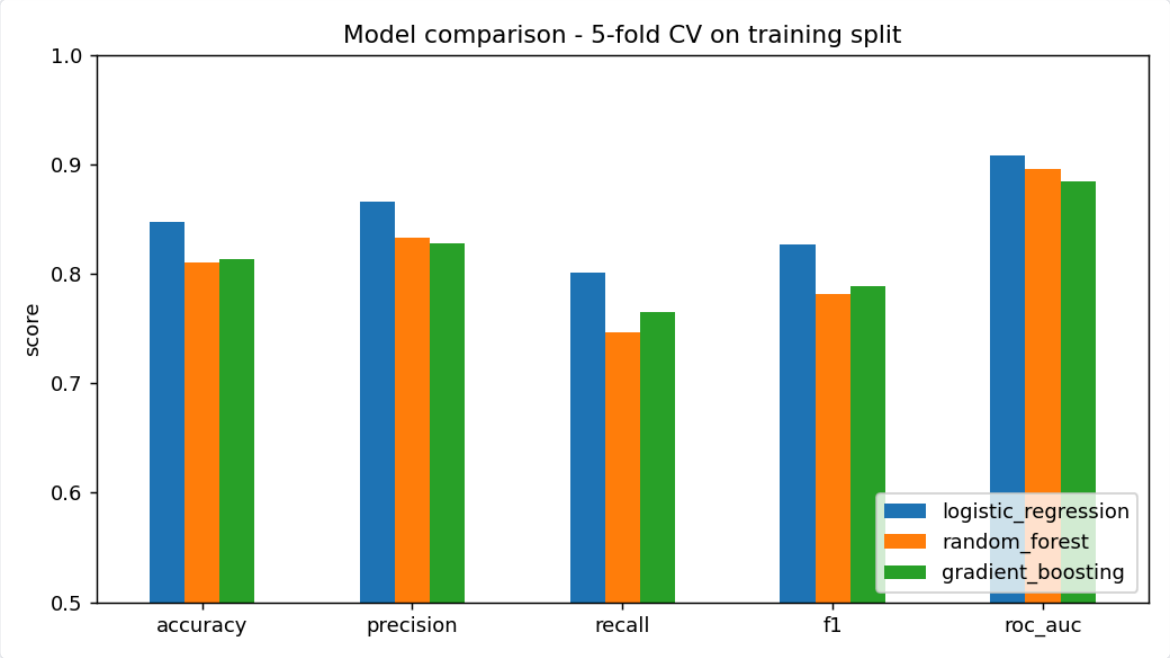
Model	Grid	Points
Logistic Regression	C ∈ {0.01, 0.05, 0.1, 0.5, 1, 5}; penalty ∈ {l1, l2}; class_weight ∈ {None, balanced}	24
Random Forest	n_estimators ∈ {200, 400}; max_depth ∈ {3, 5, None}; min_samples_leaf ∈ {1, 3, 5}; max_features ∈ {sqrt, 0.5}	36
Gradient Boosting	n_estimators ∈ {100, 200}; learning_rate ∈ {0.03, 0.1}; max_depth ∈ {2, 3}; subsample ∈ {0.8, 1.0}	16

The grids are kept small on purpose. With about 240 training rows, wide grids mostly overfit the CV folds.

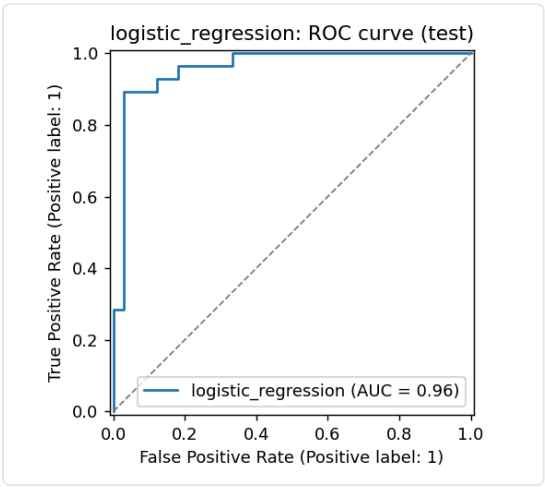
Baseline (default hyper-parameters, 5-fold CV ROC-AUC): LogReg 0.906 · RF 0.876 · GB 0.859.

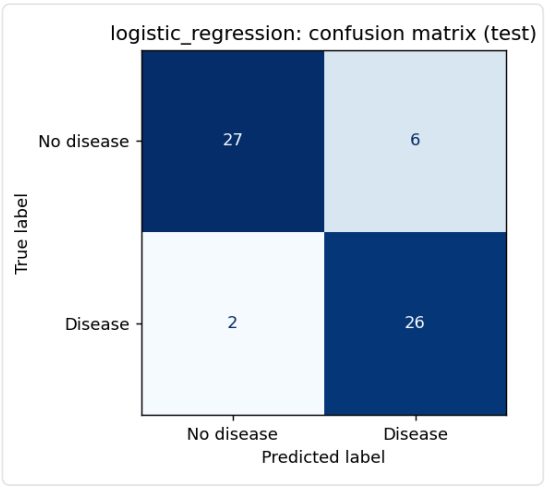
Tuned results

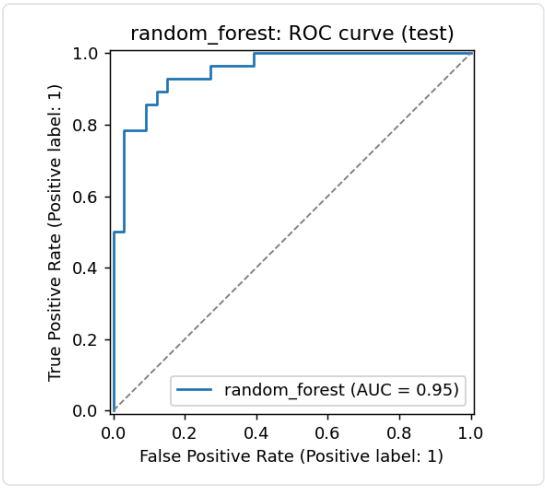
Model	Best params	CV acc	CV prec	CV recall	CV F1	CV ROC-AUC	Test acc	Test recall	Test ROC-AUC
Logistic Regression	C=0.5, L2, balanced	**0.847**	**0.866**	**0.801**	**0.827**	**0.908 ± 0.020**	0.869	**0.929**	**0.959**
Random Forest	200 trees, depth 3, sqrt	0.810	0.833	0.747	0.781	0.896	0.885	0.893	0.951
Gradient Boosting	100 trees, lr 0.03, depth 2, subsample 0.8	0.814	0.827	0.765	0.789	0.884	0.902	0.929	0.957

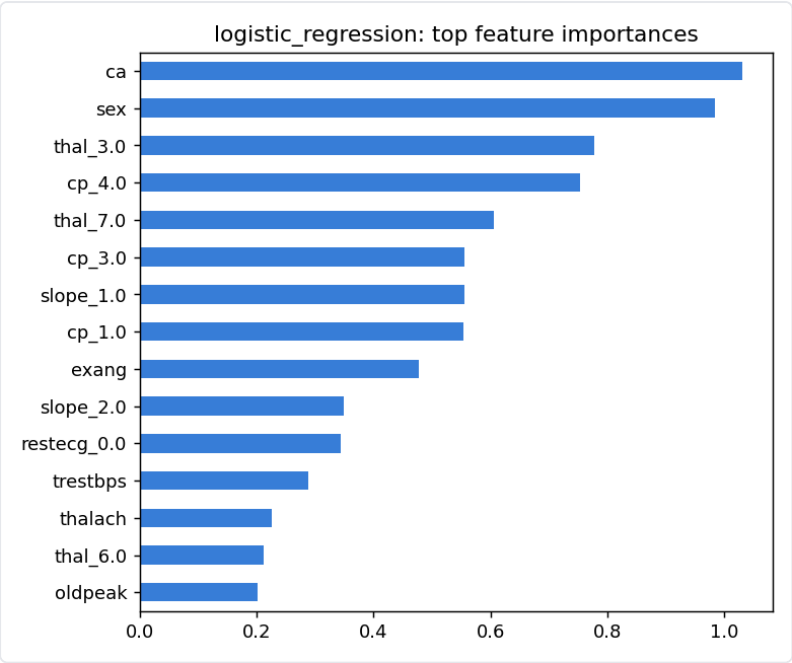


CV comparison









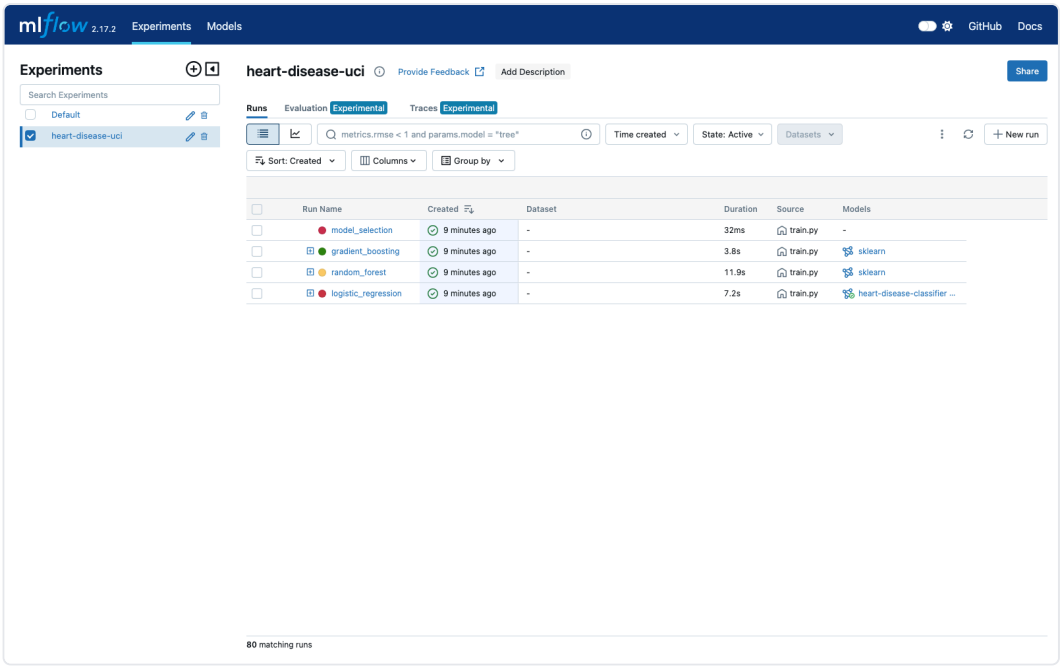
Logistic regression - absolute coefficients

Why Logistic Regression. It has the best mean CV ROC-AUC, the best CV recall and the lowest variance across folds. Tuning helped the tree ensembles most (RF went from 0.876 to 0.896), but they still trail the linear model. That is expected for a small dataset whose signal is mostly additive. Gradient Boosting has a slightly higher *test* accuracy (0.902 vs 0.869), but on 61 patients that gap is 2 patients. Choosing a model on the test set would make the test estimate optimistic. Logistic Regression also has interpretable coefficients, which matters for clinical use. The largest coefficients are `ca`, `thal=7`, `cp=4`, `sex` and `oldpeak`, which matches the EDA.

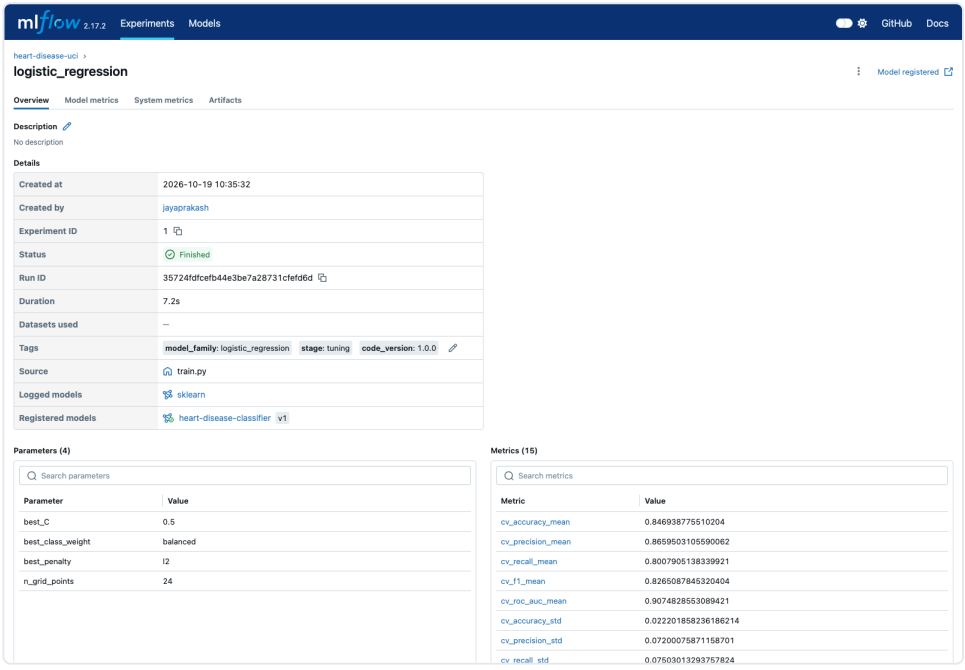
6. Experiment tracking (MLflow)

`heart.train` logs to the `heart-disease-uci` experiment (`sqlite:///mlflow.db`, artifacts under `./mlruns`). The experiment holds 80 runs in total.

- **One parent run per model family.** Each logs:
  - tags: `model_family`, `stage`, `code_version`
  - best parameters and grid size
  - 10 CV metrics (mean and std) and 5 test metrics
  - plots: confusion matrix, ROC curve, feature importance
  - the full `cv_results_` table as CSV
  - the fitted pipeline as an MLflow model, with a float signature and an input example
- **One nested child run per grid point** (76 in total), each with its parameters, CV ROC-AUC mean/std and train ROC-AUC. Comparing train and validation scores per grid point shows overfitting directly, e.g. Random Forest with `max_depth=None` averages train AUC 0.99 but CV AUC 0.885, while depth 3 gives 0.95 / 0.891.
- **A `model_selection` run** records the winner, its run id, the comparison plot and the comparison table.
- **Model registry.** The winning run is registered as `heart-disease-classifier` v1.



MLflow experiment - parent runs



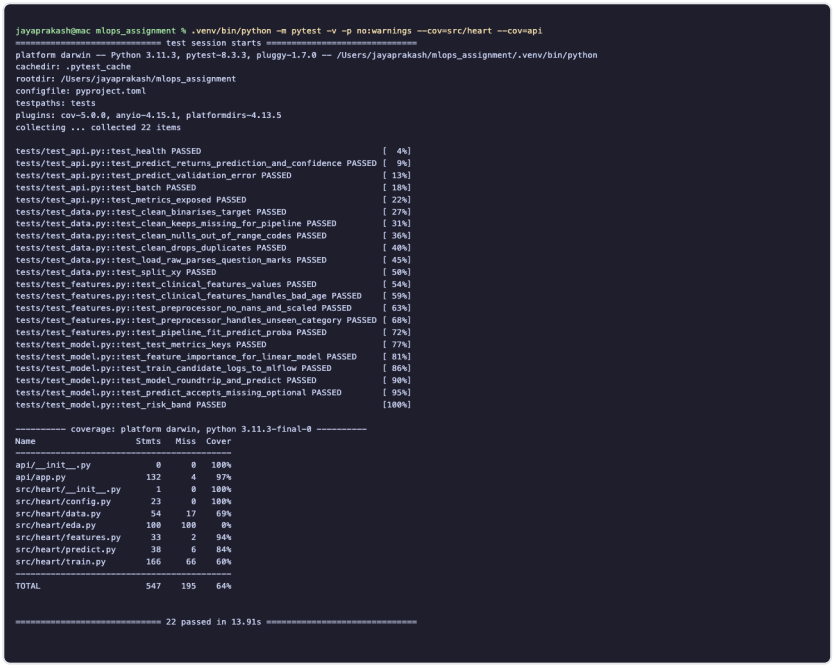
MLflow - selected run with params, metrics and registered model

7. Packaging, reproducibility and testing

- **Artefacts.**
  - `models/heart_model.joblib`: the entire pipeline, raw JSON fields → probability.
  - `models/model_metadata.json`: params, metrics, feature list, MLflow run id and training timestamp.
  - The MLflow `model/` directory: MLmodel, conda/pip env and signature.
- **Reproducibility.** Seeds are fixed. Data download and cleaning are scripted. Dependencies are pinned and locked. Missing values are imputed inside the pipeline. Unseen categories are ignored by the one-hot encoder.
- **Unit tests (22, pytest).** They use a synthetic fixture, so they need no network and run in about 10 seconds.
  - `test_data.py`: target binarisation, `?` parsing, out-of-range codes, duplicates.

- `test_features.py`: engineered feature values, NaN-free and scaled output, unseen categories, pipeline `predict_proba`.
- `test_model.py`: metric helpers, feature importance, MLflow logging of a candidate, joblib round-trip, missing optional fields, risk bands.
- `test_api.py`: health/ready, `/predict` contract, 422 validation, batch, `/metrics`.

Coverage is 97 % for the API, and 64 % overall: `eda.py` is plotting code and is run by CI instead of unit-tested.



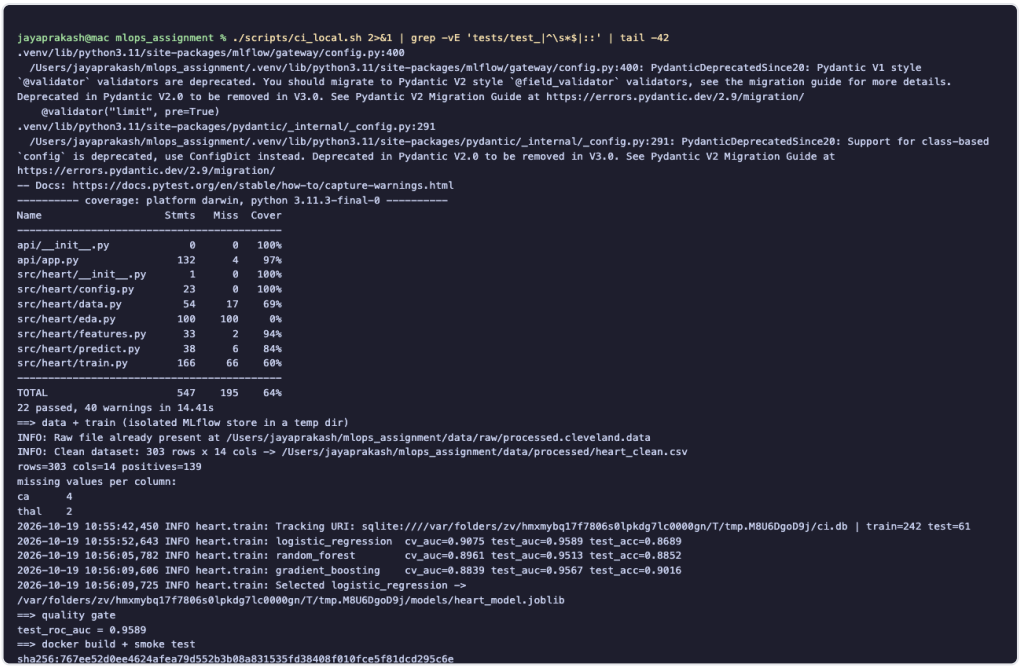
pytest

8. CI/CD pipeline (GitHub Actions)

`.github/workflows/ci.yml` runs on push to `main`, on pull requests and on manual dispatch. The jobs are chained with `needs:`, so any failure stops the pipeline and its log shows the failing step.

Job	Steps	Artifacts
`lint`	flake8 with `--show-source --statistics`	job log
`test`	install → pytest with JUnit XML and coverage XML	`test-reports/`
`train`	download → EDA → `heart.train --register` → **quality gate: test ROC-AUC ≥ 0.85**	model, `mlflow.db`, `mlruns/`, figures, `train.log`
`docker`	download model artifact → `docker build` → run container → poll `/ready` → POST `/predict` and assert the response	image tarball, `container.log`, `prediction.json`

The same stages can be run locally with `scripts/ci_local.sh`. It trains into a temporary MLflow store so the main experiment stays untouched:



Local run of the CI stages

GitHub Actions run (run 39194105001): all four jobs passed on a clean Ubuntu runner. CI training reproduced exactly the local test metrics (ROC-AUC 0.9589), which confirms the pipeline is reproducible across machines.

```
jayaprakash@mac mlops_assignment % gh run view 39194105001  # + artifacts + quality gate

✓ main ci-cd · 39194105001
Triggered via push about 5 minutes ago

JOBS
✓ lint in 9s (ID 117872991433)
✓ test in 1m38s (ID 117873037981)
✓ train in 1m24s (ID 117873445777)
✓ docker in 1m18s (ID 117873794980)

ARTIFACTS
  model-and-experiments  1511 KB
  test-reports  2 KB
  docker-image-and-logs  168331 KB

QUALITY GATE (train job)
  "test_accuracy": 0.8689,
  "test_precision": 0.8125,
  "test_recall": 0.9286,
  "test_f1": 0.8667,
  "test_roc_auc": 0.9589
}
```

GitHub Actions run - jobs, artifacts and quality gate

9. Containerisation and the serving API

The **Dockerfile** is multi-stage:

- A builder stage creates a virtualenv with only `requirements-serve.txt`.
- The runtime stage is `python:3.11-slim`. It runs as non-root UID 10001, has a `HEALTHCHECK`, and includes only `src/`, `api/` and the model.
- Uvicorn runs a single worker per container, so Prometheus counters are not split across processes. Scaling comes from Kubernetes replicas instead.

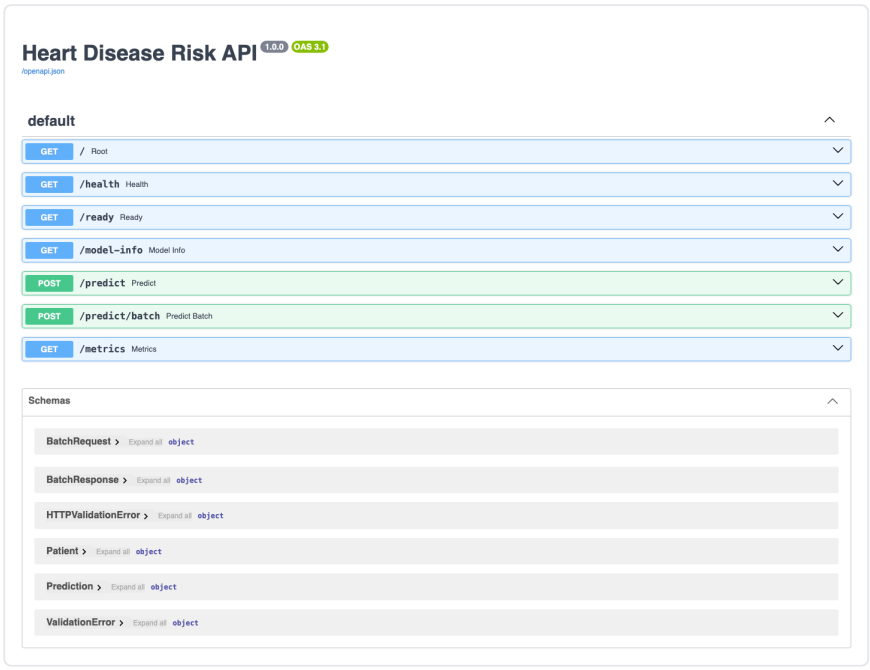
API (`api/app.py`, FastAPI)

- **Input validation.** A Pydantic schema enforces field ranges and allowed codes, so an invalid record gets HTTP 422. `ca` and `thal` are optional and imputed when missing.

- `/predict` **response.** It returns:
  - `prediction` (0/1) and `label`
  - `probability_disease`
  - `confidence`: the probability of the predicted class
  - `risk_band`: low below 0.3, moderate from 0.3 to 0.6, high above 0.6
  - the model name and version
- **Other endpoints:** `/predict/batch` (up to 500 records), `/health`, `/ready`, `/model-info` and `/metrics`.
- **Settings** come from environment variables: `MODEL_PATH`, `DECISION_THRESHOLD` and `LOG_LEVEL`.



Container run + sample prediction



Swagger UI

10. Production deployment (Kubernetes)

The target is a local **kind** cluster (`k8s/kind-cluster.yaml`). The same manifests work on GKE, EKS or AKS by changing the image reference.

- `deployment.yaml`:
  - 2 replicas, RollingUpdate (`maxUnavailable: 0`)
  - readiness probe on `/ready`, liveness probe on `/health`
  - CPU and memory requests and limits
  - non-root user, read-only root filesystem, all Linux capabilities dropped
  - `prometheus.io/*` annotations so Prometheus discovers the pods
- `service.yaml`: a ClusterIP Service for the Ingress, plus a **LoadBalancer** Service (`heart-api-lb`) that gets an external IP on cloud providers or Docker Desktop.
- `ingress.yaml`: ingress-nginx routes `localhost:8088/` to the API.

- `configmap.yaml` holds the runtime settings. `pdb.yaml` keeps at least one pod available during voluntary disruptions.
- `scripts/deploy_kind.sh` automates the whole sequence: build → create cluster → `kind load` → ingress-nginx → apply manifests → wait for rollouts.

```
jayaprakash@mac mlops_assignment % kubectl get nodes -o wide | cut -c1-110 && echo && kubectl get all,ingress,pdb,configmap -n heart-mlops && echo && kubectl
get pods,svc -n monitoring
NAME                  STATUS   ROLES           AGE     VERSION   INTERNAL-IP   EXTERNAL-IP   OS-IMAGE
heart-mlops-control-plane   Ready    control-plane   9m10s   v1.37.0   192.168.0.2   <none>        Debian GNU/

NAME                            READY   STATUS    RESTARTS   AGE
pod/heart-api-bddc78c85-kxzd5   1/1     Running   0          7m30s
pod/heart-api-bddc78c85-q2tmk   1/1     Running   0          7m30s

NAME                 TYPE           CLUSTER-IP      EXTERNAL-IP   PORT(S)        AGE
service/heart-api      ClusterIP      10.96.157.171   <none>        80/TCP         7m30s
service/heart-api-lb   LoadBalancer   10.96.63.79     <pending>     80:30315/TCP   7m30s

NAME                       READY   UP-TO-DATE   AVAILABLE   AGE
deployment.apps/heart-api   2/2     2            2           7m30s

NAME                                  DESIRED   CURRENT   READY   AGE
replicaset.apps/heart-api-bddc78c85   2         2         2       7m30s

NAME                                CLASS   HOSTS   ADDRESS     PORTS   AGE
ingress.networking.k8s.io/heart-api   nginx   *       localhost   80      7m30s

NAME                                MIN AVAILABLE   MAX UNAVAILABLE   ALLOWED DISRUPTIONS   AGE
poddisruptionbudget.policy/heart-api   1               N/A               1                     7m30s

NAME                         DATA   AGE
configmap/heart-api-config   2      7m30s
configmap/kube-root-ca.crt   1      7m30s

NAME                                READY   STATUS    RESTARTS   AGE
pod/grafana-85dbf6f4c-sx5sn       1/1     Running   0          7m24s
pod/prometheus-54cdf48c88-fh4gb   1/1     Running   0          7m25s

NAME                 TYPE       CLUSTER-IP     EXTERNAL-IP   PORT(S)          AGE
service/grafana      NodePort   10.96.239.10   <none>        3000:30030/TCP   7m24s
service/prometheus   NodePort   10.96.44.93    <none>        9090:30090/TCP   7m25s
```

kubectl resources

```
jayaprakash@mac mlops_assignment % ./scripts/smoke_test.sh http://localhost:8088 25
GET  /health      -> {"status":"ok"}
GET  /ready       -> {"status":"ready"}
POST /predict     ->
{"prediction":1,"label":"disease","probability_disease":0.8945,"confidence":0.8945,"risk_band":"high","model_name":"logistic_regression","model_version":"1.0.0"}
>> sending 25 predictions drawn from the cleaned dataset
25/25 predictions OK
invalid payload    -> HTTP 422
```

Endpoint verification through the Ingress (150 predictions OK, invalid payload → 422)

Access instructions (local testing): run `./scripts/deploy_kind.sh`, then:

```
curl -X POST http://localhost:8088/predict -H 'content-type: application/json' -d
      @sample_request.json
```

Interactive documentation is at `http://localhost:8088/docs`.

11. Monitoring and logging

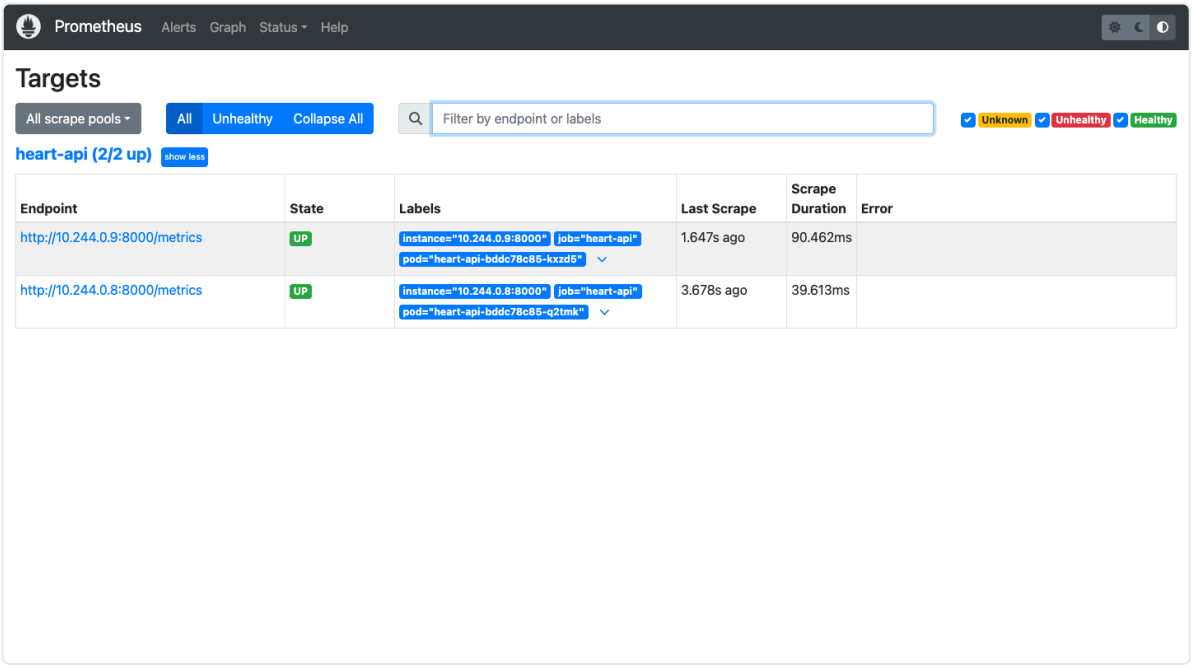
- **Request logging.** HTTP middleware writes one JSON line per request to stdout, with `request_id`, method, path, status, latency and client IP. The request id is also returned in the `x-request-id` header. Each prediction is logged with its input and output, which gives an audit trail and data for later drift analysis. Kubernetes collects these logs with `kubectl logs`.
- **Metrics (`prometheus_client`):**
  - `heart_api_requests_total{method,path,status}`
  - `heart_api_request_latency_seconds` (histogram)
  - `heart_api_predictions_total{label,risk_band}`
  - `heart_api_predicted_probability` (histogram)
  - `heart_api_model_loaded`

The probability histogram and the class mix are simple **model-behaviour monitors**. A sudden shift in the disease-positive share is an early warning of data drift.

- **Prometheus** discovers each pod and scrapes it every 5 seconds. It has three alert rules: API down, 5xx rate above 5 %, and p95 latency above 500 ms.
- **Grafana** is provisioned as code, with the datasource and dashboard JSON in ConfigMaps. The dashboard shows:
    - request totals
    - predictions served
    - disease-positive share
    - pods with the model loaded
    - request rate per endpoint
    - p50/p95 latency
    - predictions per risk band
    - HTTP status codes
    - the distribution of predicted probabilities



API request logs (JSON)



Prometheus - both replicas discovered and UP



Grafana dashboard

12. Limitations and next steps

- The dataset is small (303 patients) and comes from a single site, so the test metrics have wide confidence intervals: ±0.08 accuracy at 61 samples. External validation on the Hungarian, Swiss and VA subsets would be the next step.
- Probability calibration (isotonic or Platt) and threshold tuning for a recall target would make `confidence` more meaningful clinically.
- The model is baked into the image. A registry-driven loader that pulls the `Production` alias from MLflow would decouple model releases from image releases.
- Add a CD stage that pushes to a container registry and deploys to a cloud cluster, with canary releases and automatic rollback on the Prometheus alerts.

Appendix A: Deliverables checklist

Deliverable	Location
Code, Dockerfile, requirements	`src/`, `api/`, `Dockerfile`, `requirements*.txt`
Cleaned dataset + download script	`data/processed/heart_clean.csv`, `scripts/download_data.py`
Notebooks (EDA, training, inference)	`notebooks/01_eda.ipynb`, `02_model_training.ipynb`, `03_inference.ipynb`
Unit tests	`tests/`
CI workflow	`.github/workflows/ci.yml`
Deployment manifests	`k8s/`, `k8s/monitoring/`
Screenshots	`screenshots/` (21 images)
Report	`reports/MLOps_Assignment1_Report.pdf` / `.docx`
API access	§10 access instructions